STOP.



Open only after everyone has voted.

This file names the person responsible. Hosts: don't open it, don't print-preview it. When every ballot is in, a volunteer turns to page 4 and reads Script 5 aloud.

The Gravy Boat Murder

A Cozy Friendsgiving Murder Mystery · 6–12 players

SOLUTION · OPEN LAST

The Solution

THE CULPRIT

Morgan Feld, the cookbook editor

How: at about 5:33 Morgan took Jules's sleeping tablets from Jules's coat in the mudroom, crushed them in the hayloft inside a folded proof page, and at 5:50 slipped through the pantry's back door and stirred them into Goldie's gravy boat.
Why: Morgan had quietly taken $3,600 from the cookbook's royalty account, and Goldie was about to tell everyone.

The clue chain (6 steps)

STEP	SOURCE	WHAT IT PROVES
1	E1 + E5	The sleeping tablets were added to the boat in the pantry between 5:30 and 5:58. Goldie filled the boat at 5:30 and fetched it at 5:58 (E1); the tablets were stirred in after the gravy went into the boat, and the pot was fine (E5).
2	E2 + Booklet 10 (R2) + Booklet 11 (R2)	The way in was the mudroom door, at about 5:50. Avery and Sage were in the kitchen the whole time, and only Goldie used the kitchen door. Right after the 5:50 oven timer, the back latch from the mudroom (E2: "clacks") clacked twice, a minute apart, and at no other time.
3	E7 + Booklets 12, 14, 15 (R2)	At 5:50 Casey and Jules were on the porch and Quinn was pouring cider beside Goldie, all on video. With Avery and Sage in the kitchen, Morgan is the only core guest nobody can place.
4	E8 + E9 + E2 + Booklet 15 (R2)	The tablets came from Jules's coat in the mudroom (E8; Jules joked about them in the hall at about 5:00). The empty bottle was hidden in the hayloft, which can only be reached by the ladder in the mudroom (E9, E2).
5	E9 + E10	The bottle was wrapped in a proof page covered in red-pencil corrections. Only two copies of the proofs exist: Goldie's, still sealed, and the editor's, Morgan Feld's.
6	E11 + Booklet 12 (R3)	The motive: the royalty statement was $3,600 short and "M." had until the announcement to confess (E11). Morgan has looked after the royalty account for three years (12 R3). Sage Montrose is also "M.," but was in the kitchen (step 2).

Key evidence numbers for scoring: E1, E2, E5, E7, E8, E9, E10, E11.

Why Not the Others?

11 SUSPECTS CLEARED

SUSPECT	WHY THEY LOOKED SUSPICIOUS	WHY IT WASN'T THEM
10 Avery Quill	Café plans; argued with Goldie about the barn's name; knows the pantry.	In the kitchen with Sage 5:25–6:00 (11 R2); the tablets went in from the mudroom side.
11 Sage Montrose	Copied pie recipe (E12); another "M."	In the kitchen with Avery (10 R2); never handled the cookbook money (12 R3).
12 Quinn Delacroix	Page-1 cider recipe; muddy prints (E6); outside alone 5:39–5:46.	The prints never go near the pantry or ladder (E6); beside Goldie at 5:50 on video (E7).
14 Casey Thornbury	Goldie was leaving the show; "wild" mushrooms (E3).	No mushrooms involved (E5); on camera on the porch at 5:50 (E7).
15 Jules Carraway	The tablets were Jules's (E8, E9); inherits the gravy boat; owed $2,000.	On the porch on camera at 5:50 (E7); the bottle was wrapped in the editor's proof page (E9, E10).
16 Harper Lindqvist	Carrot grudge; sells a valerian sleepy tea.	In the root cellar (outside entrance) 5:35–5:58; the doctor found pharmacy tablets (E5).
17 Skyler Bontempo	Lost a promised guest spot on the show.	In the food truck behind the barn 5:30–5:58; saw the hayloft light.
18 Arden Fairweather	Casserole insult; away 5:30–5:56.	At home next door; came in the front door at about 5:56, after the 5:50 latch.
19 Indigo Pike	Farm dropped from the book; "You'll regret this."	In the barn office on a 23-minute call, 5:35–5:58.
20 Charlie Okonjo	Unpaid cheese bill; losing the show's business.	In the milk room 5:15–5:55; tasted the gravy pot at 5:18 and is fine.
21 Wren Abernathy	Uncredited family gravy recipe; "We need to talk."	On the road; crossed the bridge at about 5:45 and walked in at 6:00.

Optional characters (16–21) are cleared by their own alibis; the case never depends on them.

Script 5 · The Reveal

A VOLUNTEER READS ALOUD

READ ALOUD

Thank you, everyone. Here is what happened at Juniper Barn. Goldie's run-of-show card tells us she filled her silver boat at half past five and left it under her napkin on the pantry's warming shelf until two minutes to six. Dr. Linden tells us the sleeping tablets were stirred into the gravy after it went into the boat, and the pot was fine. So someone reached that boat in the pantry between half past five and two minutes to six.

Avery and Sage were in the kitchen the whole time, and nobody but Goldie came through the kitchen door. But right after Sage's oven timer rang at ten to six, they heard the pantry's back latch, the one from the mudroom, clack twice, a minute apart. At that moment Casey's camera shows Casey and Jules on the porch and, through the window, Quinn pouring cider beside Goldie. Only one of Goldie's oldest friends is missing from every account.

The tablets came from Jules's coat in the mudroom. The empty bottle turned up in the hayloft, and the only way up is the ladder in that same mudroom. It was wrapped in a page of the cookbook proofs, covered in red-pencil corrections. Only two copies of those proofs exist: Goldie's, still sealed, and the editor's.

The person responsible is Morgan Feld. For three years Morgan looked after the cookbook's royalty account and quietly took $3,600 from it. Goldie found the gap and gave "M." until the announcement to confess. Instead, Morgan took Jules's tablets, waited in the hayloft and slipped into the pantry at ten to six. Morgan, please take a bow. And everyone: thank you for the most memorable Friendsgiving Juniper Barn has ever seen. Raise your cider, your coffee or your pie fork, to Goldie.

THEN

Hand back to the host to score the ballots (page 5) and give out the awards.

Scoring & Awards

BALLOT LINE	CORRECT ANSWER	POINTS
Who spoiled the gravy?	Morgan Feld	3
How?	Stirred Jules's crushed sleeping tablets into the gravy in Goldie's gravy boat in the pantry, at about 5:50 (any answer naming the sleeping tablets and the gravy boat).	2
Why?	To stop Goldie from revealing that Morgan had taken $3,600 from the cookbook royalties (any answer about the cookbook money).	2
Key evidence	One point each for E1, E2, E5, E7, E8, E9, E10 or E11	max 3
Best possible score		**10**

Half points

- "How" that names the gravy boat but not the tablets (or the tablets but not the boat): 1 point.
- "Why" that says "Goldie was going to expose a secret" without the money: 1 point.

Awards (file 34)

- **Best Detective:** highest ballot score. Ties go to the most correct evidence numbers.
- **Best Performance:** vote by applause. Morgan is eligible, especially if nobody guessed.
- **Best Dish:** vote by applause for the potluck dish everyone went back to for seconds.

> THANK YOU
>
> We hope The Gravy Boat Murder gave your Friendsgiving a story to retell for years.
> Questions? chenphien@gmail.com · Clue & Candle Games